

THE APPROACH

The King's Crusade – Module Ten

OVERVIEW

The coalition's final march brings it within sight of Caer Ysolde — and for the first time since Landfall, the party sees what the deepest drainage actually looks like, at the scale of a capital rather than a mile of road. This module also introduces the resistance leader in person: the member of the royal house who escaped the fall of the kingdom and has refused every offer of evacuation since. Nothing here forces the campaign's central choice. It only makes sure the table has actually sat with it before Module Eleven asks. Core scenes run three and a half to four hours; Optional Content fills out the rest of a five-hour session and can be cut cleanly if the table is short on time.

A QUIET MODULE ON PURPOSE

Resist adding combat to pad this module's length. Its entire job is weight and reflection after Module Nine's real cost, and a fight here would undercut that rather than serve it. If a table wants more to do, use Optional Content rather than inventing an encounter — this is one of the few modules in the campaign built to run under its target time without anything having gone wrong.

Scene	Target time	Notes
1. The Last Miles	20–30 min	The march's final stretch; accumulated weight, not new danger.
2. Caer Ysolde, Dark	30–40 min	First sight of the capital. The Standing Light has failed here.
3. The Regent	60–75 min	The resistance leader, met in person for the first time.
4. The Price	30–40 min	Doria Kell names what Norvatch wants. No combat; the module's hardest scene.
5. What Waits at the Gates	30–45 min	The turn-back-or-hold question, weighed narratively.
Optional Content	30–45 min	Run if the table has time; cut cleanly if not.

WHAT IS ACTUALLY HAPPENING (DM ONLY)

Aveline Ysolde has spent three years running a resistance that could never win, on purpose — not to defeat the occupation, which was never possible with the forces available, but to make sure Elduvaine never became a place that had simply accepted Vale. She knows a great deal about the deepest state of the drainage, about the Archive's vaults from the outside, and about what the rest of her house actually wants for the kingdom afterward, which is not

something they all agree on. None of this resolves the campaign's central open question — what Elduvaine should become after the war — and this module should not resolve it either.

DM Only: she is a real, developed person and not an exposition device, and the sourcebook gives her a position: Elduvaine free, and the Ysolde Archive closed. Permanently, and by law. A kingdom that can be opened with a key should not keep the key. Let her hold that opinion in front of a party who have marched here under a Promise that includes the run of that Archive, and let her be entirely aware of what she is saying to them. Do not use her to state a correct answer to the turn-back-or-hold question — that is the table's, and a later session must not reweight it, including through this NPC's own considerable certainty.

DM Only: three years of occupation have not caught her, and the reason is worth knowing before you play her. Her great-grandmother married into the Braid out of a Harrowmark trading family, which makes Aveline the closest thing this royal house has to a foreigner — and in a country where everybody is known, she is the one Ysolde who knows how to be unremarkable. She has refused evacuation in writing, twice, to two different coalition commanders who put it to her as a kindness.

SCENE 1: THE LAST MILES

The road from the field battle to Caer Ysolde is the campaign's longest quiet stretch, and it should feel like one. Let the party notice how much has actually changed since Duncarrow: who they have lost, who they have freed, and how little any of it resembles the war they thought they were marching into.

Nobody talks much on the last day's march. It isn't grim exactly — more that everyone in the column seems to be doing the same private arithmetic, adding up what the last several months have actually cost against what they came here for, and none of them are quite ready to say the sum out loud.

This scene has no mechanical content. Let the party talk to whichever recurring NPCs the campaign has given them — the Ward, the Magistrate, Brenna Vane, Sera Vosk or Garrick Hollow, a captured Drell or Voss if either survived — about anything at all. This is the campaign giving its own cast room to be people rather than plot before the finale asks something of all of them.

SCENE 2: CAER YSOLDE, DARK

The column crests a final rise, and Caer Ysolde is below them — the capital where three rivers braid together, exactly as the sourcebook describes it, except for the one thing no description quite prepares a party for.

It is dark. Not ruined, not besieged-looking from this distance — simply dark, in a way a city its size has apparently never been before tonight, its pale stone holding no more light than any ordinary quarry's would. Somewhere down there is the Ysolde Archive, the largest collection of magical knowledge in the world, and the party is looking at the exact place the sourcebook already told them the draining hits first and hardest.

Let this land as the wonder-into-grief beat it is meant to be, deliberately paired against Module Three's Caerwyn glowing at dusk. If a player remarks on the contrast, that is the scene working exactly as intended — do not have an NPC explain it; let the silence around the column do that.

SCENE 3: THE REGENT

A resistance contact — cautious, testing the party before committing to anything — leads them to a meeting the coalition's own officers have been trying and failing to arrange for weeks: Aveline Ysolde, Regent of Elduvaine, in person, for the first time.

She is younger than the party expects and very much plainer — forty-one, no crown, no court dress, a coat as travel-worn as anything Doria Kell wears, and the specific unremarkableness of somebody who has spent three years being looked past in her own country. "Three years I have been told, by people who mean well, that I should let myself be taken somewhere safe," she says, by way of greeting. "I have found that safe and useful are very rarely the same offer. You, I take it, are neither."

RUNNING THE SCENE

Aveline will speak plainly about what the resistance actually knows: the drainage's current state, Vale's pattern of movement within the city (he is rarely seen and never predictably), and, if asked directly, her own view on what should happen to Elduvaine afterward — a view the sourcebook establishes her own house does not share. Let this be a real conversation with a real person who has earned the right to an opinion, not a briefing. No skill check gates any of it; she gives it freely to people she has decided, correctly, are worth trusting. She is also clear-eyed about what her resistance actually is, and will describe it in exactly those terms: a miller who miscounts, two orchard-keepers who hide people, a clerk who forges permits in the same hand she once used to file requisitions. Not an army. A conspiracy of small, patient, deniable treason.

DM Only: if the party freed Ninian at Sennoch Hall and Ottoline at Vindana, this is where Aveline asks after her cousins by name and as people rather than as political assets — and where she finds out, probably from the party rather than from them, that Ninian has been telling coalition officers the Promise cannot be paid. Let that land as real family feeling complicated by three years apart and by a disagreement none of them has had the chance to have out loud yet. She will not have it out here either. She will note it, and change the subject, and the party will notice her doing it.

SCENE 4: THE PRICE

Before the coalition moves on Caer Ysolde, Doria Kell finds the party one more time — sent for, if they went looking after Vindana; arriving unannounced if they did not. She has brought a folio, a contract, and no small talk.

"Three years of purchase records," she says, setting the folio down but not letting go of it. "Everything Norvatch has bought out of this kingdom since the night the wards opened, by weight and by date. You want it because it is the only honest answer to the question none of your commanders can answer: how much of Elduvaine is actually left, and therefore how long you have."

"The price is a signature. Norvatch's trading rights in a liberated Elduvaine, guaranteed, in writing, by your king. He has no authority to give me that — I am aware. He had no authority to promise the Archive to Oksitan either, and he did it in front of witnesses, and here we all are."

This is the module's hardest scene and it has no combat in it. The information is real and Doria is not lying about any part of it: the ledgers say what she says they say, the price is exactly what she names, and Norvatch will honour whatever is signed to the letter and forever. Xavier will sign it if the party tells him to, and will look at them while he does it.

What it costs is not money. It is that the same kingdom has now been promised three times over. The Call offered land inside the Living Realm and the run of the Ysolde Archive to everybody who answered it — not one thing each to two powers, the same two things to both, which nobody in the coalition has yet said out loud. And now the standing right to buy the place by the cartload, to a realm that never marched a soldier. Every one of those is payable only on an Elduvaine that is taken and held, and the party is one module away from deciding whether it will be.

DM Only: refusing is a real option with a real cost, and the module must not tilt it. A party that refuses walks into Module Eleven not knowing how much of the kingdom is left, which is exactly as frightening as it sounds and entirely survivable. A party that signs walks in knowing — and knowing, too, that they have made the settlement one degree harder for whoever has to write it. Neither is the correct answer. Record which in the Branch Ledger and move on without comment.

DM Only: if the party asks what the ledgers actually say, give them a real number and let it be worse than they hoped: somewhere near a third of the Living Realm's resident magic is already gone, the rate has been climbing for a year, and Vale is not slowing down. Do not translate that into a countdown of days. It is a direction of travel, not a timer, and the party should feel hurried rather than scheduled.

SCENE 5: WHAT WAITS AT THE GATES

Before the final push, let the coalition's leadership — and the party themselves — sit with the question the whole campaign has been building toward without answering: take Elduvaine, or, having proven it can be done, choose not to hold it.

Nobody puts it that bluntly. It comes out instead as smaller questions, asked by different people for different reasons — an Oksitan officer asking what happens to the Promise if the coalition marches home early; the Magistrate asking, very precisely, what "victory" is actually meant to mean here; Xavier, quieter than usual, asking the party directly whether they think this is a kingdom that wants saving on the coalition's terms.

Do not resolve this scene with a decision. Its entire purpose is to make sure the table has heard the question asked seriously, by people with real stakes in the answer,

before Module Eleven makes them answer it. End the module on the coalition making final preparations — supply, formation, the ordinary business of an army about to do something enormous — and hand off directly to Module Eleven.

TIERED SKILL DCs

Easy 10, Moderate 13, Hard 16, matching the tiers used throughout this campaign. Nothing in the Regent’s meeting is gated behind a check; these are for the edges of it.

Task	Skill	DC	Tier
Satisfy Aveline’s contact that the party is who it says it is	Persuasion / Insight	13	Moderate
Read the resistance’s chalk signs on the lock gates	Investigation	13	Moderate
Notice Aveline changing the subject away from Ninian	Insight	16	Hard
Read what Doria Kell will not negotiate on	Insight	13	Moderate
Convert the ledgers into a single number without help	Intelligence	16	Hard

STAT BLOCKS

None. This module has no fights by design, and a DM tempted to add one should use Optional Content instead. Aveline Ysolde has a block in the Bestiary, and it is there only so that a DM knows what happens to anybody who corners her.

PUZZLES AND SET PIECES

Reading the Ledgers follows the price scene and adds twenty minutes, and only happens at all if the party bought the folio. The Regent’s Council is the counsel scene, with the question turned around and put to the party instead.

THE PUZZLE: READING THE LEDGERS

If the party bought Doria Kell’s folio, they now hold three years of purchase records and no idea what they mean. The arithmetic is the puzzle, the answer is a single number, and the number is worse than anybody hoped.

Norvatch records by weight and by date, not by kind, because Norvatch is buying tonnage and does not care what the tonnage was. Four columns and nothing else:

Year	Cut light-stone, tons	Other cargo, tons	What the party can work out
One	1,400	9,100	Ordinary trade, plus a little. This is close to a normal year for Vindana.

Year	Cut light-stone, tons	Other cargo, tons	What the party can work out
Two	4,200	8,900	The other cargo has not moved. The light-stone has tripled.
Three	19,200	8,400	And then more than quadrupled. The curve is not linear and has not flattened.

The insight is that the ordinary cargo is flat, which means Elduvaine’s actual economy is unchanged and everything in the increase is the draining. And cut light-stone is not building stone: it is the medium, drained and packaged, and every ton of it is a piece of the Living Realm in a cart.

A character with the Archive Clerk or Season-Keeper background, or a DC 16 Intelligence check by anyone, converts it. Cairn Ithel’s masons can say how much resident magic a ton of cut stone will hold. The Season-Keepers at Nantcorrow have the map of which woods have turned and in what order. Put the two together and the number comes out.

“Something near a third of it. A third of the Living Realm, gone through Vindana in three years, and the rate has been climbing every quarter and has not once slowed. That is what you have bought. I did tell you it was not good news. I only ever said it was true.”

DM Only: give them the number and do not turn it into a countdown of days. It is a direction of travel, not a timer, and the party should feel hurried rather than scheduled. Two things follow that the DM should let land on their own: the curve is accelerating, which means the fourth year is worse than the first three combined; and a party that refused the folio walks into Module Eleven without any of this, which is exactly as frightening as it sounds and is entirely survivable. Neither is the correct answer and the module must not tilt it.

SET PIECE: THE REGENT’S COUNCIL

A miller, two orchard-keepers, a forger who used to file requisitions, and the last free member of the royal house of Elduvaine, in the back of a lock-house eleven miles from the capital, deciding what to ask the coalition for.

“There are seven of us and a table. Aveline Ysolde is at the head of it because somebody has to be, not because anyone here would call her that out loud, and she has a list in front of her in a hand so small it is almost a cipher. She does not stand up when you come in. She says: sit down, we have four hours, and I would like to know what your king thinks he has promised, because we have heard three versions and none of them can all be true.”

She is right, and the three versions are not three different promises. They are the same one, made to everybody at once: land where the habits work, and the run of the Archive, to whoever answered. Two powers have been marching eight months on the assumption that there is enough of it to go round. And if the party signed in this module, there is now a third instrument on top, guaranteeing a realm that never marched a soldier the right to buy the place by the cartload. Every one of them is payable only on an Elduvaine that is taken and held. Nobody asked Elduvaine.

DM Only: there is a fourth thing in the pile and Aveline does not know about it, because Oksitan has never said it plainly to anybody outside its own court. Oksitan does not primarily want an estate and does not much care about the Archive. Oksitan wants the Willing Road — the waystones, and the craft of cutting more — which is not on offer, has never been on offer, and cannot be given by anybody. If the party has worked that out by now, this is the room to say it in, and it makes the arithmetic worse rather than better: one of the two powers owed a share is owed something that does not exist.

What the resistance wants to know, in order: what the coalition has been promised. Who is expected to pay it. Whether the Concord's Tenth Work is going to be permitted to do what it has been openly saying it will do. And whether the party will tell them the truth about any of it.

The party can lie. It works. Aveline is not a lie detector and the meeting ends warmly and the resistance opens every door in the Braid for them. It also means the first time an Elduvish parish watches a Tenth Work chapter house go up on ground that had an Observance on it, somebody in that room will remember who said it would not happen.

DM Only: there is no check to pass here and nothing to win. This is the campaign asking the party, once, directly, what they actually think the crusade is for, in front of the people it is nominally being fought for. Whatever they say goes in the Branch Ledger verbatim. Do not editorialise, do not have Aveline approve or disapprove, and do not resolve it in this module or the next one.

NPC PROFILES

AVELINE YSOLDE, THE REGENT

Human, forty-one, in a family that mostly is not, and the only member of Elduvaine's royal house who was outside a wall on the night the wards opened — a fact she has never once described as luck. Speech: measured, unsentimental, entirely unbothered by three years of danger that would have broken most people. She has genuinely considered leaving and genuinely chosen not to, more than once, and has put the refusal in writing twice. She has a stat block in the Bestiary, which she will not need and which is there because a DM should know what happens to anybody who corners her.

Open thread: the Regent's own view on Elduvaine's future is theirs to hold and the campaign's not to adjudicate — a DM developing the endgame should treat their opinion as one real voice among several in the royal house, not the deciding one.

OPTIONAL CONTENT

THE RESISTANCE, BRIEFLY

The Regent's people are exactly as unglamorous as the kingdom that produced them: a halfling miller who has been miscounting the levy for two years, two elven orchard-keepers who between them have hidden eleven people, a gnome who used to file Archive requisitions and now forges permits with the same handwriting. Nobody here is a soldier. All of them have been committing small, patient, deniable treason since before the coalition sailed.

If the table wants more of Elduvaine's ordinary resistance before the finale, let them meet a handful of the Regent's people directly — farmers, former Archive clerks, people who have been doing small, unglamorous sabotage for three years rather than anything a story would call heroic. No mechanical stakes; pure texture, and a chance to make the liberated feel like people rather than a cause.

LETTERS HOME

If the table wants a quiet character scene, let each PC write (or dictate, or simply compose in their head) a letter home before the finale — to Harrowmark, to wherever they came from, to whoever they left behind. No mechanical content; this is purely for the players who want a moment of reflection before the campaign's climax.

LISSWATER

The road upriver along the Braid runs through Lisswater: eleven halfling villages along nine slow miles of the middle river that consider themselves one place, the best food in Elduvaine, and the strongest Listening Water in the kingdom. It is also where Aveline's miller lives — the one who has been miscounting the levy for two years and would very much like to stop being the only person doing it.

Lisswater's etiquette about the water is nine centuries deep and outsiders find it incomprehensible: you do not speak at the edge about anything you would not repeat, and you do not stand there angry. A party that breaks the rule is not scolded. It is quietly and permanently regarded as unserious, and every door in eleven villages is exactly as open as it was before and not one inch more.

If the table wants to hear once more what happened somewhere it was not — the fall of the capital, the capital's Standing Light going out quarter by quarter over fourteen months, the royal house taken in a single night — this is the place for the Four Voices, and the Echo of the Listening Water (Bestiary) is the way to deliver it as a thing in the room rather than a riverbank. Four voices, none lying, none complete. Do not let anybody fight it. If they attack it, it leaves, and Lisswater will know.

DIVERGING PATHS (DM ONLY)

- **Whether Xavier signed Norvatch's contract.** Signed, refused, or deferred — track which, and who in the party argued for it. A signed contract means the coalition has

promised the same kingdom three times and the party knows how much of Elduvaine is left; a refusal means they walk into the finale without that number. This is the last entry added before the campaign's final choice and it bears directly on it.

- **What the party told Aveline, and what Aveline told them.**

Not mechanically trackable in the usual sense, but worth a DM's private note — this conversation is the table's clearest signal yet of which way they are leaning on the campaign's central question, and it is worth remembering going into Module Eleven.

LOOT

Nothing material. This module, like Module Three and Module Five before it, is not about treasure. Its currency is entirely the conversation in Scenes 3 and 4.

THE REFRAIN

*By thought, and by word, and by deed,
the king's own chosen kept their creed.
Far from home, where the quiet land lay,
they held the line, and would not stray.*